

US Patent & Trademark Office

Patent Public Search | Text View

United States Patent Application Publication

20250269764

Kind Code

A1

Publication Date

August 28, 2025

Inventor(s)

BURJES; ROGER W. et al.

ELECTRIC POWERTRAIN HAVING INTERAXLE ELECTRIC POWER TRANSFER

Abstract

An electric powertrain for a work vehicle including a first electric machine connected to a first axle, a second electric machine connected to a second axle, a battery connected to the first and second electric machines, a brake connected to the second axle, an actuator connected to the brake, and a controller configured to operate the first electric machine in a generator mode which generates electrical energy from the rotational energy of the first axle, the second electric machine in a motor mode which provides rotational energy to the second axle, and the actuator to apply the brake which absorbs rotational energy from the second axle.

Inventors: BURJES; ROGER W. (CEDAR FALLS, IA), HOLLAND; MICHAEL A. (CONRAD, IA), NEUMANN; CLAYTON P. (CEDAR FALLS, IA)

Applicant: DEERE & COMPANY (MOLINE, IL)

Family ID: 1000008047481

Appl. No.: 18/790183

Filed: July 31, 2024

Related U.S. Application Data

us-provisional-application US 63557362 20240223

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: B60L58/15 (20190101); B60L7/26 (20060101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC B60L58/15 (20190201); B60L7/26 (20130101); B60L2200/40 (20130101)

Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS [0001] This application claims the benefit of U.S. Provisional Application No. 63/557,362, titled ELECTRIC POWERTRAIN HAVING INTERAXLE ELECTRIC POWER TRANSFER, filed Feb. 23, 2024, which is hereby incorporated by reference.

FIELD OF THE DISCLOSURE

[0002] The present disclosure relates to an electric powertrain for a work vehicle.

BACKGROUND

[0003] Powertrains for work vehicles may include one or more types of onboard power sources to provide propulsion and other power during operation. In general, some work vehicles may contain an internal combustion engine. Other work vehicles may have electrical machines in addition to or instead of the internal combustion engine, and such electrical machines may operate as motors or generators to supply mechanical or electrical power to various components.

SUMMARY

[0004] According to an aspect of the present disclosure, an electric powertrain for a work vehicle includes a first electric machine connected to a first axle, a second electric machine connected to a second axle, a battery connected to the first and second electric machines, a brake connected to the second axle, an actuator connected to the brake, and a controller configured to operate the first electric machine in a generator mode which generates electrical energy from the rotational energy of the first axle, the second electric machine in a motor mode which provides rotational energy to the second axle, and the actuator to apply the brake which absorbs rotational energy from the second axle.

[0005] According to an aspect of the present disclosure, in a first mode, the controller is configured to direct substantially all the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the battery.

[0006] According to an aspect of the present disclosure, the controller is configured to direct the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the battery when the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine is at or below a charging current threshold of the battery.

[0007] According to an aspect of the present disclosure, in a second mode, the controller is configured to allocate the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine between the battery and the second electric machine.

[0008] According to an aspect of the present disclosure, the controller is configured to allocate the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the battery and the second electrical machine when the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine is above a charging current threshold of the battery.

[0009] According to an aspect of the present disclosure, the controller allocates a first portion of the generated electrical energy to the battery and a second portion of the generated electrical energy to the second electric machine, and the first portion is an amount at or below the charging current threshold of the battery.

[0010] According to an aspect of the present disclosure, in a third mode, the controller is configured to direct substantially all the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the second electric machine.

[0011] According to an aspect of the present disclosure, the controller is configured to allocate the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the second electrical machine when the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine is above a charging current threshold of the battery.

[0012] According to an aspect of the present disclosure, the controller is configured to operate the first electric machine in the generator mode, the second electric machine in the motor mode, and the actuator to apply the brake when the controller determines a requirement to reduce the speed of the work vehicle.

[0013] According to an aspect of the present disclosure, the controller is configured to determine a quantity of generated electrical current to send the battery, based on one or more of the amount of generated electrical energy, the charge status of the battery, and the temperature of the battery.

[0014] According to an aspect of the present disclosure, a work vehicle includes the electric powertrain disclosed in any of the implementations herein.

[0015] The above and other features will become apparent from the following detailed description and accompanying drawings.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0016] The detailed description refers to the accompanying figures in which:

[0017] FIG. 1 is a perspective view of a work vehicle, according to an implementation;

[0018] FIG. 2 is a schematic view of an electric powertrain, according to an implementation;

[0019] FIG. 3 is a schematic view of an electric powertrain, according to an implementation;

[0020] FIG. 4 is a schematic view of an electric powertrain, according to an implementation;

[0021] FIG. 5 is a schematic view of an electric powertrain, according to an implementation; and

[0022] FIG. 6 is a schematic view of an electric powertrain, according to an implementation.

[0023] Like reference numerals are used to indicate like elements throughout the several figures.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0024] The embodiments or implementations disclosed in the above drawings and the following detailed description are not intended to be exhaustive or to limit the present disclosure to these embodiments or implementations.

[0025] With reference to FIG. 1, a work vehicle **100**, for example an agricultural tractor, can include an operator station or cab **102**, a hood **104**, one or more ground engaging apparatus **106**, for example wheels or track assemblies, and a frame or chassis **110**. The work vehicle **100** can include an operator interface having any number and combination of electronic devices, such as an interactive display. The work vehicle **100** can have a rigid or an articulated frame **110**. The work vehicle **100** can include an electric powertrain **120** providing power to one or more ground engaging apparatus **106** and one or more power take off (PTO) shafts or other auxiliary power outputs or inputs. This disclosure also applies to other types of work vehicles in agriculture, construction, forestry, and road building.

[0026] With reference to FIGS. 2-6, an electric powertrain **120** includes a first axle **124** and a second axle **128**. The first and second axles **124**, **128** can be either front or rear axles. A first electric machine **122** is connected to the first axle **124** and a second electric machine **126** is connected to the second axle **128**. The first electric machine **122** can connect to the first axle **124** via a first gearbox **132**. The second electric machine **126** can connect to the second axle **128** via a second gearbox **136**. The first and second gearboxes **132**, **136** can include one or more sets of gears having one or more gear ratios between the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** and the first and second axles **124**, **128**. The first and second gearboxes **132**, **136** can include one or more clutches. The first and second electric machines **122**, **126** can be DC or AC electric machines (e.g., DC or AC motor/generators).

[0027] An electrical energy storage device **140** (e.g., an electric battery) is connected to the first and second electric machines **122**, **126**. The electrical energy storage device **140** can include one or more batteries, each having one or more cells. The electrical energy storage device **140** can have an

operational status, a charge level status, and a temperature status. The electrical energy storage device **140** can have a charging current limit or threshold. A battery management system (BMS) **142** can monitor and manage the health and status of the electrical energy storage device **140**. Hereinafter, the electrical energy storage device **140** will be referred to as a battery **140**.

[0028] The electric powertrain **120** can include one or more power converters **146** (e.g., converter, inverter, etc.) positioned between the battery **140** and the first and second electric machines **122**, **126**. The one or more power converters **146** can be positioned near one or more of the first electric machine **122**, the second electric machine **126**, and the battery **140**. The one or more power converters **146** can be a DC-to-DC converter, when the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** are DC electric machines, or an AC-to-DC inverter, when the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** are AC electric machines. The electric powertrain **120** can include one or more relays or switches **148** positioned between the battery **140** and the first and second electric machines **122**, **126**. The one or more switches **148** can connect and disconnect the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** to or from each other and the battery **140**.

[0029] A brake **150** (e.g., friction brake) can be connected to one of the first axle **124** and the second axle **128**. According to some implementations, the brake **150** is connected to only one of the first and second axles **124**, **128**. The brake **150** includes an applied mode and a released mode. An actuator **152** can apply and release the brake **150**. The actuator **152** can include a hydraulic, pneumatic, or electrical actuator **152** (e.g., hydraulic cylinder, pneumatic cylinder, or linear actuator).

[0030] The first and second electric machines **122**, **126** each have a generator mode generating electrical energy and a motor mode producing mechanical or rotational energy. In the generator mode, each of the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** can operate as a generator, which creates an electrical current (e.g., an AC or DC current) generated from rotational energy or power. In the motor mode, each of the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** can operate as a motor, which produces rotational energy or power in response to an electrical current (e.g., an AC or DC current). The first and second electric machines **122**, **126** can be any type of AC or DC electric machine (e.g., any type of motor-generator). Each of the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** can provide electrical energy to recharge the battery **140**, to the other electric machine, to the actuator **152**, to other electrical or electric components, storage devices, or consumers, or to any combination of the preceding.

[0031] An electronic control unit or controller **160** is connected to the first and second electric machines **122**, **126**, the battery **140**, and the actuator **152**. The controller **160** can direct electrical energy to or from the first and second electric machines **122**, **126**, the battery **140**, the actuator **152**, and other electric components, storage devices, and consumers. The controller **160** can operate each of the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** in the generator or motor mode. The controller **160** can operate the one or more relays or switches **148** to direct or allocate the electrical energy between the first and second electric machines **122**, **126**, the battery **140**, the actuator **152**, and other electric components, storage devices, and consumers.

[0032] In one example, the controller **160** can operate the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** in the motor mode. The battery **140** provides electrical energy to the first and second electric machines **122**, **126**. The controller **160** can direct electrical energy from the battery **140** to the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** in any allocation based in part on traction, terrain, vehicle speed, work operation, obstacles, draft load, operator input, etc.

[0033] In another example, the controller **160** can operate both the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** in the generator mode. The controller **160** can direct the generated electrical energy from the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** to one or more of the battery **140**, the actuator **152**, and other electric components, storage devices, or consumers. The controller **160** can use this operation to reduce the speed (e.g., slow or stop) of the work vehicle **100**.

[0034] In another example, the controller **160** can operate the first electric machine **122** in the

generator mode and the second electric machine **126** in the motor mode. In a first mode, the controller **160** directs all or substantially all the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine **122** to the battery **140**. In a second mode, the controller **160** allocates or distributes the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine **122** between the battery **140** and the second electric machine **126**. In a third mode, the controller **160** directs all or substantially all the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine **122** to the second electric machine **126**. The controller **160** can use this operation to reduce the speed of the work vehicle **100**.

[0035] In another example, the controller **160** can operate the first electric machine **122** in the motor mode and the second electric machine **126** in the generator mode. The controller **160** can direct the generated electrical energy from the second electric machine **126** to one or more of the first electric machine **122**, the battery **140**, the actuator **152**, and other electric components, storage devices, or consumers. The controller **160** can use this operation to reduce the speed of the work vehicle **100**.

[0036] The controller **160** can determine when to direct electrical energy to or from the first and second electric machines **122**, **126**, the battery **140**, the actuator **152**, and other electric components, storage devices, and consumers. For example, when the controller **160** determines there is a need, requirement, intent, or request to reduce the speed of the work vehicle **100**, the controller **160** can operate one or more of the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** in the generator mode. The controller **160** can determine there is a need, requirement, intent, or request to reduce the speed of the work vehicle **100** based in part on terrain, vehicle speed, work operation, obstacles, operator input, etc.

[0037] The controller **160** can direct the generated electrical energy from the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** to recharge the battery **140**. The controller **160** can determine whether to charge the battery **140**, and a quantity of electrical current to send the battery **140**, based on one or more of the following: the amount of generated electrical energy or current, the charge status or condition of the battery **140**, the temperature of the battery **140**, the age of the battery **140**, the demand for electrical current from other electric components, storage devices, or consumers, and the status or condition of any systems of the work vehicle **100**.

[0038] The controller **160** is connected to and communicates with the sensors described herein. The controller **160** can determine the amount of generated electrical energy or current from the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** measured by one or more current sensors **162** positioned anywhere in the electrical circuit connecting the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** with the battery **140**. The controller **160** can determine the health and status of the battery **140** measured by one or more sensors **144**, **164**, **166** or the battery management system **142**. The controller **160** can determine the charge status or condition (e.g., state of charge or SoC) of the battery **140** measured by a voltage sensor **164**, one or more other sensors **144**, or the battery management system **142**. The controller **160** can determine the temperature of the battery **140** measured by a temperature sensor **166**, one or more other sensors **144**, or the battery management system **142**. The controller **160** can determine the demand for electrical current from other electric components, storage devices, or consumers measured by one or more current sensors **168**. The controller **160** can determine the status or condition of the systems of the work vehicle **100** measured by various other sensors **170** (e.g., speed sensor, torque sensor, inclinometer sensor, location sensor, position sensor, etc.).

[0039] The controller **160** is connected to and communicates with the one or more power converters **146** and the one or more relays or switches **148**. The controller **160** can control the one or more switches **148** to connect or disconnect the first electric machine **122** to or from the second electric machine **126**, the battery **140**, or both. The controller **160** can control the one or more switches **148** to connect or disconnect the second electric machine **126** to or from the first electric machine **122**, the battery **140**, or both. The controller **160** can operate the one or more relays or switches **148** to direct or allocate the electrical current between the first and second electric

machines **122**, **126** and the battery **140**.

[0040] When the controller **160** determines the generated electrical energy from one or more of the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** is at or below the charging current threshold of the battery **140**, then the controller **160** can direct the generated electrical energy to the battery **140**. According to some implementations, the controller **160** can perform additional evaluations or assessments before directing any generated electrical energy to the battery **140**. The controller **160** can determine whether the operational status of the battery **140** is functioning or malfunctioning based in part on one or more sensors **144**, **164**, **166** or a controller **142** (e.g., battery management system) providing the operational status. The controller **160** can determine whether the charge level status is below, at, or above a preselected charge level (e.g., charge percentage) based in part on the voltage sensor **164** or battery management system **142**. The controller **160** can determine whether the temperature status is below, at, or above a preselected temperature based in part on the temperature sensor **166** or battery management system **142**. The controller **160** can determine to direct or allocate the generated electrical energy to the battery **140** when the battery **140** is functioning, below the preselected charge level, and below the preselected temperature.

[0041] When the controller **160** determines the generated electrical energy from one or more of the first and second electric machines **122**, **126** is above the charging current threshold of the battery **140**, then the controller **160** can operate the first electric machine **122** in generator mode, operate the second electric machine **126** in the motor mode, operate the actuator **152** to apply the brake **150**, and allocate the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine **122** between the battery **140** and the second electrical machine **126**. The first electric machine **122** converts rotational energy from the first axle **124** into electrical energy. The second electric machine **126** converts electrical energy into rotational energy for the second axle **128**. The brake **150** absorbs or removes rotational energy from the second axle **128**. The controller **160** can direct or allocate a first portion of the generated electrical energy to the battery **140** and a second portion of the generated electrical energy to the second electric machine **126**. The first portion can be any amount at or below the charging current threshold of the battery **140**, and the second portion is any remaining or excess amount.

[0042] The electronic control unit or controller **160** can have one or more microprocessor-based electronic control units or controllers, which perform calculations and comparisons and execute instructions, for example algorithms. The controller includes a processor, a core, volatile and non-volatile memory, digital and analog inputs, and digital and analog outputs. The controller can include non-transitory, computer readable memory, such as random-access memory (RAM), read only memory (ROM), or electrically erasable programmable read only memory (EEPROM), which include instructions for execution by the processor, for example algorithms. The controller connects to and communicates with various input and output devices including, but not limited to, switches, relays, solenoids, actuators, light emitting diodes (LED's), passive and interactive displays, radio frequency devices (RFD's), sensors, and other controllers. The controller receives communications or signals, via electrically or any suitable electromagnetic communication, from one or more devices, determines an appropriate response or action, and sends communications or signals to one or more devices. The controller can be a microprocessor, an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC), a digital processor, or a programmable logic controller, also known as a PLC or programmable controller. The controller can connect to and communicate with an electronic control system of the work vehicle **100**, the electric powertrain **120**, or both through a data bus, such as a CAN bus, or the controller can be a part the electronic control system of the work vehicle **100**, the electric powertrain **120**, or both.

[0043] The terminology used herein is for the purpose of describing example embodiments or implementations and is not intended to be limiting of the disclosure. As used herein, the singular forms “a,” “an,” and “the” are intended to include the plural forms as well, unless the context clearly indicates otherwise. It will be further understood that the any use of the terms “has,”

“includes,” “comprises,” or the like, in this specification, identifies the presence of stated features, integers, steps, operations, elements, and/or components, but does not preclude the presence or addition of one or more other features, integers, steps, operations, elements, components, and/or groups thereof.

[0044] Those having ordinary skill in the art will recognize that terms such as “above,” “below,” “upward,” “downward,” “top,” “bottom,” etc., are used descriptively for the figures, and do not represent limitations on the scope of the present disclosure, as defined by the appended claims. Furthermore, the teachings may be described herein in terms of functional and/or logical block components or various processing steps, which may include any number of hardware, software, and/or firmware components configured to perform the specified functions.

[0045] Terms of degree, such as “generally,” “substantially,” or “approximately” are understood by those having ordinary skill in the art to refer to reasonable ranges outside of a given value or orientation, for example, general tolerances or positional relationships associated with manufacturing, assembly, and use of the described embodiments or implementations.

[0046] As used herein, “e.g.,” is utilized to non-exhaustively list examples and carries the same meaning as alternative illustrative phrases such as “including,” “including, but not limited to,” and “including without limitation.” Unless otherwise limited or modified, lists with elements that are separated by conjunctive terms (e.g., “and”) and that are also preceded by the phrase “one or more of” or “at least one of” indicate configurations or arrangements that potentially include individual elements of the list, or any combination thereof. For example, “at least one of A, B, and C” or “one or more of A, B, and C” indicates the possibilities of only A, only B, only C, or any combination of two or more of A, B, and C (e.g., A and B; B and C; A and C; or A, B, and C).

[0047] While the above describes example embodiments or implementations of the present disclosure, these descriptions should not be viewed in a restrictive or limiting sense. Rather, there are several variations and modifications which may be made without departing from the scope of the appended claims.

Claims

1. An electric powertrain for a work vehicle, comprising: a first electric machine connected to a first axle; a second electric machine connected to a second axle; a battery connected to the first and second electric machines; a brake connected to the second axle; an actuator connected to the brake; and a controller configured to operate the first electric machine in a generator mode which generates electrical energy from the rotational energy of the first axle, the second electric machine in a motor mode which provides rotational energy to the second axle, and the actuator to apply the brake which absorbs rotational energy from the second axle.
2. The electric powertrain of claim 1, wherein in a first mode, the controller is configured to direct substantially all the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the battery.
3. The electric powertrain of claim 2, wherein the controller is configured to direct the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the battery when the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine is at or below a charging current threshold of the battery.
4. The electric powertrain of claim 1, wherein in a second mode, the controller is configured to allocate the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine between the battery and the second electric machine.
5. The electric powertrain of claim 4, wherein the controller is configured to allocate the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the battery and the second electrical machine when the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine is above a charging current threshold of the battery.
6. The electric powertrain of claim 4, wherein the controller allocates a first portion of the generated electrical energy to the battery and a second portion of the generated electrical energy to

the second electric machine, and the first portion is an amount at or below the charging current threshold of the battery.

7. The electric powertrain of claim 1, wherein in a third mode, the controller is configured to direct substantially all the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the second electric machine.

8. The electric powertrain of claim 7, wherein the controller is configured to allocate the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the second electrical machine when the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine is above a charging current threshold of the battery.

9. The electric powertrain of claim 1, wherein the controller is configured to operate the first electric machine in the generator mode, the second electric machine in the motor mode, and the actuator to apply the brake when the controller determines a requirement to reduce the speed of the work vehicle.

10. The electric powertrain of claim 1, wherein the controller is configured to determine a quantity of generated electrical current to send the battery, based on one or more of the amount of generated electrical energy, the charge status of the battery, and the temperature of the battery.

11. A work vehicle having an electric powertrain, comprising: a first electric machine connected to a first axle; a second electric machine connected to a second axle; a battery connected to the first and second electric machines; a brake connected to the second axle; an actuator connected to the brake; and a controller configured to operate the first electric machine in a generator mode which generates electrical energy from the rotational energy of the first axle, the second electric machine in a motor mode which provides rotational energy to the second axle, and the actuator to apply the brake which absorbs rotational energy from the second axle.

12. The work vehicle of claim 11, wherein in a first mode, the controller is configured to direct substantially all the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the battery.

13. The work vehicle of claim 12, wherein the controller is configured to direct the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the battery when the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine is at or below a charging current threshold of the battery.

14. The work vehicle powertrain of claim 11, wherein in a second mode, the controller is configured to allocate the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine between the battery and the second electric machine.

15. The work vehicle of claim 14, wherein the controller is configured to allocate the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the battery and the second electrical machine when the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine is above a charging current threshold of the battery.

16. The work vehicle of claim 14, wherein the controller allocates a first portion of the generated electrical energy to the battery and a second portion of the generated electrical energy to the second electric machine, and the first portion is an amount at or below the charging current threshold of the battery.

17. The work vehicle of claim 11, wherein in a third mode, the controller is configured to direct substantially all the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the second electric machine.

18. The work vehicle of claim 17, wherein the controller is configured to allocate the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine to the second electrical machine when the generated electrical energy from the first electric machine is above a charging current threshold of the battery.

19. The work vehicle of claim 11, wherein the controller is configured to operate the first electric machine in the generator mode, the second electric machine in the motor mode, and the actuator to apply the brake when the controller determines a requirement to reduce the speed of the work vehicle.

20. The work vehicle of claim 11, wherein the controller is configured to determine a quantity of generated electrical current to send the battery, based on one or more of the amount of generated electrical energy, the charge status of the battery, and the temperature of the battery.
